

## Scientific and medical ethics



Advances in science and medicine are usually regarded as mainly beneficial to society, but some have opened up a whole new field of ethical discussion. New discoveries in medicine, for example, have improved both the length and quality of life, which on the face of it is clearly morally good. Nevertheless, we must weigh up their benefits against issues such as animal testing, human embryo research, the morality of commercial drug companies and so on. Medical procedures such as abortion and the thorny problem of euthanasia also pose ethical dilemmas that are far from clear-cut. Just about every area of scientific research involves decisions that have

a moral dimension: genetically modified crops, cloning, energy production and especially weapons research are all areas that require ethical scrutiny. There is also the question of cost – money spent on projects such as space exploration or particle accelerators is difficult enough to justify in simple economic terms, but can it be morally justified when so much of the world's population is living in extreme poverty?